

Responsible investing trends report: Now, next, later | Q3 2026 edition

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Short-term trends (6–12 months): Three trends are reshaping sustainable finance. First, water is becoming a national security and investment priority. More detailed water data is informing portfolio risk assessments, central bank analysis, and company capex plans, although water still ranks behind energy security. Second, Asia is rapidly developing biodiversity taxonomies, led by the People's Bank of China and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations. These frameworks may expand further across the region and globally. Third, stewardship and proxy voting are becoming harder to navigate because requirements differ by region. Governance leads in the US, human rights lead in Japan, and climate proposals are losing momentum globally.

Medium-term trends (2–5 years): Over the next few years, markets will increasingly reward credible, forward-looking climate strategies as climate events intensify. The same emphasis on preparedness is spreading to resilience, as worsening disasters push investors away from after-the-fact responses and toward adaptation finance. Global adoption of the International Sustainability Standards Board standards supports both shifts and gives investors a clear, comparable disclosure baseline. Nature-related guidance will probably follow a similar path to climate disclosure.

Long-term trends (5+ years): Over the longer term, climate change and conflict are redrawing trade routes. Low water levels in the Panama Canal and the Rhine during this summer's heat waves, combined with disruption in the Strait of Hormuz, are accelerating interest in Arctic shipping and Eurasian rail freight. However, Russian control of the Northern Sea Route adds regulatory risk. Decarbonization is advancing in key transport sectors, as International Maritime Organization net-zero talks, green ports, and electric vessels reshape shipping. In aviation, incorporating the Carbon Offsetting

and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation into EU law should increase demand for high-quality carbon credits.

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